Essential Biology, Biol 115

General information
Term and year: Fall 2025
Restrictions: For students outside the Faculty of Science; not for those who completed BIOL 111, BIOL 112, or equivalents.
Course schedule: Tuesday and Thursdays; 8:35 – 9:55 AM in McMed 522
Number of credits: 3 credits

Instructors' information

Dr. Gemma de Martino (instructor & course coordinator)
Email: gdm@example.edu
Office location: N3/2

Dr. Sarah Woolley (instructor & TA coordinator)
Email: sw@example.edu

Teaching assistants (TAs)

Aleksei Sychterz
Email: as@example.edu

Sabrina Percy
Email: sp@example.edu

Ev Berger-Wolf
Email: ebw@example.edu

Communicating with instructors:
Post content questions on the discussion board first.

The midterm will be written OCT 20 from 7- 9 PM (outside class time). Rooms will be posted in early October.

The final exam will cover material only presented after the midterm and will be written during the final exam period.

All exams will only cover lecture material and use multiple-choice questions.

Course policies on deadlines
Deadlines help TAs return feedback quickly.
For assignment 2 (Fun Fact) - it must be in at least 3 days before the lecture. Late assignments lose 10% per day.
For assignments 1, 3 and 4, each student has a late "bank" of 6 days for the semester.

Course policies on Generative AI
Students may use generative AI tools as learning aids, but remain accountable for their work.

Course content & key milestones

Date	Day	Lectures	Topic	Assignments
1-Sep	Tues		Welcome and course overview, meet the instructors	Lit.A & B start
3-Sep	Thurs	Lect.1	Scientific Method (Woolley)	
			MODULE 1: Life, Diversity, and Evolution (Woolley)	
8-Sep	Tues	Lect.2	Fundamentals of Evolution: Natural Selection	
10-Sep	Thur	Lect.3	Fundamentals of Evolution: Sexual Selection	
15-Sep	Tues	Lect.4	Fundamentals of Evolution: Drift and adaptation	Fun fact and Q&A assignments start with lecture 4 on Sep 15. Check your group number.
29-Sep	Tues	Lect. 8	Brain Evolution: Evolution of Language	
13-Oct	Tues		Fall Break	
20-Oct	Tues	Lect.11	The Chemistry of Life: Water and Macromolecules	Midterm Exam on Modules 1 & 2 at 7
29-Oct	Thur	Lect.14	Cellular Energy &Respiration	Deadline for LitB video Oct.29
24-Nov	Tues	Lect.21	Complex Inheritance and Human Genetics (Sychterz)	Deadline for LitA short essay Nov 24

McGill policy statements

- Language of submission
  Students may submit graded written work in English or French. (Approved by Senate on 21 January 2009)
- Academic integrity
  McGill University values academic integrity. See McGill University's guide to academic honesty.

Assignments
Instructions and rubrics for each assignment follow.

Assignment 1 – Multiple choice questions and answers

The purpose of this assignment is to check your understanding of the lecture by writing two multiple choice questions (with answers).

Value: 5% of final grade

Submission: Online through myCourses as a PDF or Word document

Deadline: Always due at 11:59 PM, 5 days after the assigned lecture is presented. Upload to myCourses Assignment 1 tab

Lectures are assigned to individuals in myCourses -> Groups -> Multiple Choice

The bank of extension dates is applicable for this assignment.

Grading Scheme for multiple choice Q&A (per question and answers):
Clarity /0.5 per question

Assignment 2 - Fun Fact Assignment

You will be assigned a lecture to present a fun fact slide about.

Value: 10% of final grade

Deadline: Always due at 11:59 PM, 3 days BEFORE the assigned lecture so that it can be presented in class. Upload to myCourses Assignment 2 tab

Lectures are assigned via the Groups tab on myCourses - Consult the FUN FACT groups

A late penalty of 10% per day will apply to this assignment. The bank of extension dates is NOT applicable.

Grading Scheme for fun fact assignment (/10 total)

Assignment 3 – Literature assignment A

Find a biology news item published since January 1, 2026 and evaluate how reliable its source is.

Value: 15% of final grade

Deadline: November 24, by 11:59 PM uploaded to myCourses Assignment 3 tab.

Grading Scheme for Lit A Assignment (/15 total)
Signed up for article by Sept 11 /0.5

Assignment 4 – Literature assignment B: News Article Video Assignment

Make a 2.5–3 minute video explaining a recent finding from a news article.

Example reference: Writer, A. (2021, September 14). A science story. Science News.

Value: 20% of final grade

Submission: Online through myCourses in Assignment 4 tab.

Deadline: October 29th, 2026, at 11:59 PM uploaded to myCourses Assignment 4 tab

The bank of extension dates is applicable for this assignment.

Grading Scheme for Lit B assignment: